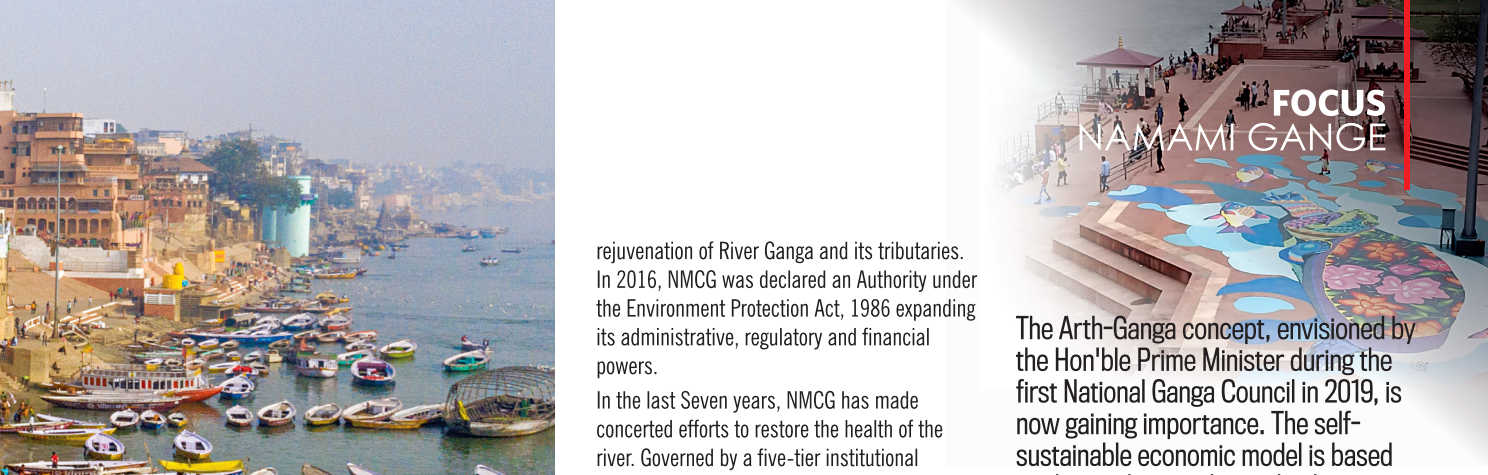
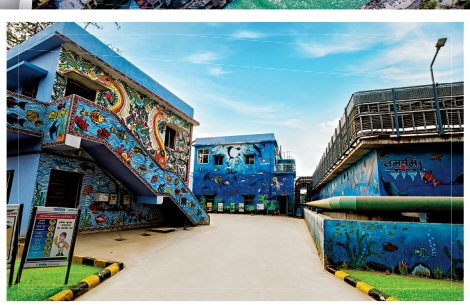


The Arth-Ganga concept, envisioned by the Hon'ble Prime Minister during the first National Ganga Council in 2019, is now gaining importance. The self-sustainable economic model is based on the symbiotic relationship between nature and society, by primarily strengthening people-river connect and adopting an ecologically conscious sustainable development framework.

Ganga has been the lifeline of the country from times immemorial and revered as a deity. With a holistic and multi-sectoral approach, the Namami-Gange Program was launched in 2015 with National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG) as its implementing agency to rejuvenate River Ganga in an integrated and holistic manner, bringing it back to its pristine glory. It is based on a comprehensive river rejuvenation program- the Ganga River Basin Management Plan- prepared by consortium of 8 IITs, not limited to just pollution abatement but also focuses on the restoration of ecology around the entire Ganga basin and communicating to people the social, religious and economic relevance of the River. Namami-Gange, indeed, marked a major policy shift and ushered in a paradigm shift in river rejuvenation. With a budgetary outlay of Rs 20,000 Cr for a period of 5 years, Namami-Gange adopted a holistic and multi sectoral approach for the conservation, protection and rejuvenation of River Ganga and its tributaries. In 2016, NMCG was declared an Authority under the Environment Protection Act, 1986 expanding its administrative, regulatory and financial powers.



In the last Seven years, NMCG has made concerted efforts to restore the health of the river. Governed by a five-tier institutional structure, the mission has recognized five areas of strategic interventions- Nirmal-Ganga (Unpolluted-Flow), Aviral-Ganga (Unrestricted-Flow), Jan-Ganga (People-River Connect) Gyan-Ganga (Knowledge Management) and Arth-Ganga (economic-connect). 354 projects worth Rs 31,099 Cr have been sanctioned under various components of the Mission, out of which 210 have already been completed. Moreover, over 5,024 MLD wastewater treatment capacity and 5,134 km sewer network has been sanctioned for the Ganga basin. Innovative best practices such as One City One Operator and Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM) has enabled greater performance-based accountability in the sewerage infrastructure in the Ganga basin and has been a game changer in the Indian wastewater sector. The historical ecological flow notification of 2018 recognizes the right of the river over its own water and has set a precedent for the recognition of the rights of all other rivers as well.

The other initiatives include industrial pollution abatement, wetlands and biodiversity conservation, afforestation, wastewater recycle and reuse, floodplain management, groundwater management, small rivers and spring rejuvenation, river front development through ghats, crematoria and kunds, specialized research and development studies, water quality monitoring, amongst others. Transitioning of the mission into a Jan-Andolan has been a result of the efforts of the dedicated cadres of Ganga saviors such as Ganga-Mitras, Ganga Vichar Manch, Ganga-Praharis and Ganga-Doots. Public outreach activities like Ganga-Utsav, Nadi-Utsav, Ganga-Quest, India Water Impact Summit and regular cleanathons, shramdaan and plantation drives has helped to sustain the spirit of Jan-Bhagidari for the cause of Ma-Ganga. Rag-Rag-Mein-Ganga travelogue on Doordarshan captured various locations along River Ganga that holds importance. Afforestation initiatives have resulted in trees and plants afforested in over 35,000 Ha area; the bio-diversity protection initiatives in increased sightings of species such as Turtles, Ghariyals, Hilsa, etc. and improved water quality, with the stretch till Haridwar reaching class A standard (highest water quality).

It comprises multi-sectoral interventions ranging from development of natural farming to livelihood interventions, are to be achieved through synergies at different institutional levels, coupled with adoption of decentralized governance practices. The model strives to contribute at least 3% of the GDP from the basin itself.

The key verticals of intervention under Arth Ganga are zero budget natural farming, monetization of reuse of sludge and treated wastewater, promotion of livelihood generation opportunities, increased public participation, revival of cultural heritage and tourism and institutional building. Some of the key initiatives planned and undertaken under Arth-Ganga with the support of the ministries concerned include promoting chemical-free natural farming in 5-10 km wide corridors along the river Ganga, organic farming being taken in over 1.24 lakh ha. in the states of Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Jharkhand; reuse of treated wastewater and STP sludge for agriculture and industrial purposes; development of multimodal transportation linkages such as community jetties, fairway development, Ro Ro terminals etc. with Inland Waterways Authority of India; comprehensive cultural mapping of river Ganga by INTACH; projects sanctioned for the development of Gangotri and Yamnotri Dham; development of tourism and boat tourist circuits; training over 1500 Ganga Praharis for public outreach and promotion of livelihood opportunities; projects sanctioned by ICAR-CIFRI for fisheries and livelihood linkages etc.

Today, Namami-Gange Mission has been extended for a second phase till 2026, with a budgetary allocation of another Rs 22,500 Cr. The focus shall be on increasing sewage treatment capacity on the tributaries, scaling up PPP efforts, promoting Arth-Ganga concepts: circular water economy model, fecal sludge and septage management, monetization of economic benefits of the Ganga River Basin through ecologically sustainable measures.